Part 4: Tie-Breaking Essay

These notes are not intended to be understood as a key for the Tie-Breaking Essay prompt; rather, they should serve the judge(s) as a presentation of critical ideas that might appear in an essay responding to the prompt.

Criteria for judging the Tie-Breaking Essay **SHOULD** include

the degree to which the instructions have been followed,

the quality of the critical insight offered in response to the selection,

the overall effectiveness of the written discussion, and

the grammatical correctness of the essay.

Note well that the quality of the contestant's critical insight is more important than the contestant's prose style. In short, the Literary Criticism contest is one that promotes the critical analysis of literature. The quality of the writing, which should never go unappreciated, does not trump evidence of critical analysis.

Critical Notes on Berry's "The Peace of Wild Things" and Roethke's "'Long Live the Weeds'"

Literary concepts that MIGHT be used by the contestant in a discussion of these poems include

alliteration,
contrast,
diction,
imagery,
meter,
sigmatism,
style,
theme, and
tone.

The contestant has been asked to discuss each poet's response to nature, especially in terms of his reliance on nature as community—to which, the contestant should perceive, the personas feel themselves intimately connected.

The contestant might note that while Berry's persona turns to nature upon feeling despair, Roethke's persona begins with a praising of nature—an all-inclusive praising that enumerates the weeds, the rocks, the rough, the wicked. His or her essay might dwell on this contrast: Berry's turning to beauty for solace "for a time" and Roethke's recognizing the not-so-beautiful as kindred and as something that he wishes will give him shape.

The young writer might focus on Berry's explicit imagery and Roethke's simple diction, which are curiously matched with Berry's free verse and Roethke's formal meter and rhyme. The need for solace or succor sends Berry's persona looking for the unbound and varied beauty of nature, and Roethke's persona desires to earn a participatory union with the foundational elements, the bitter rock and barren soil, of nature. Though the needs and the approaches differ, each persona turns to nature as an outsider looking for communion.

A contestant who has been engaged in literary analysis for some time might recognize in Roethke's paradox, "The ugly of the universe. / [. . .] / That keep[s] the spirit undefiled," something of the Mariner's blessing of the water-serpents in Coleridge's "Rime." He or she might see in Berry's "peace of wild things / who do not tax their lives with fore-thought / of grief" something of Robert Burns's contemplation of the mouse and her not guessing that her best laid plans might go awry. His or her discussion might focus on man's long-recognized turning to nature for comfort.